

The Back Forty



DORMANT

Soy · 1965

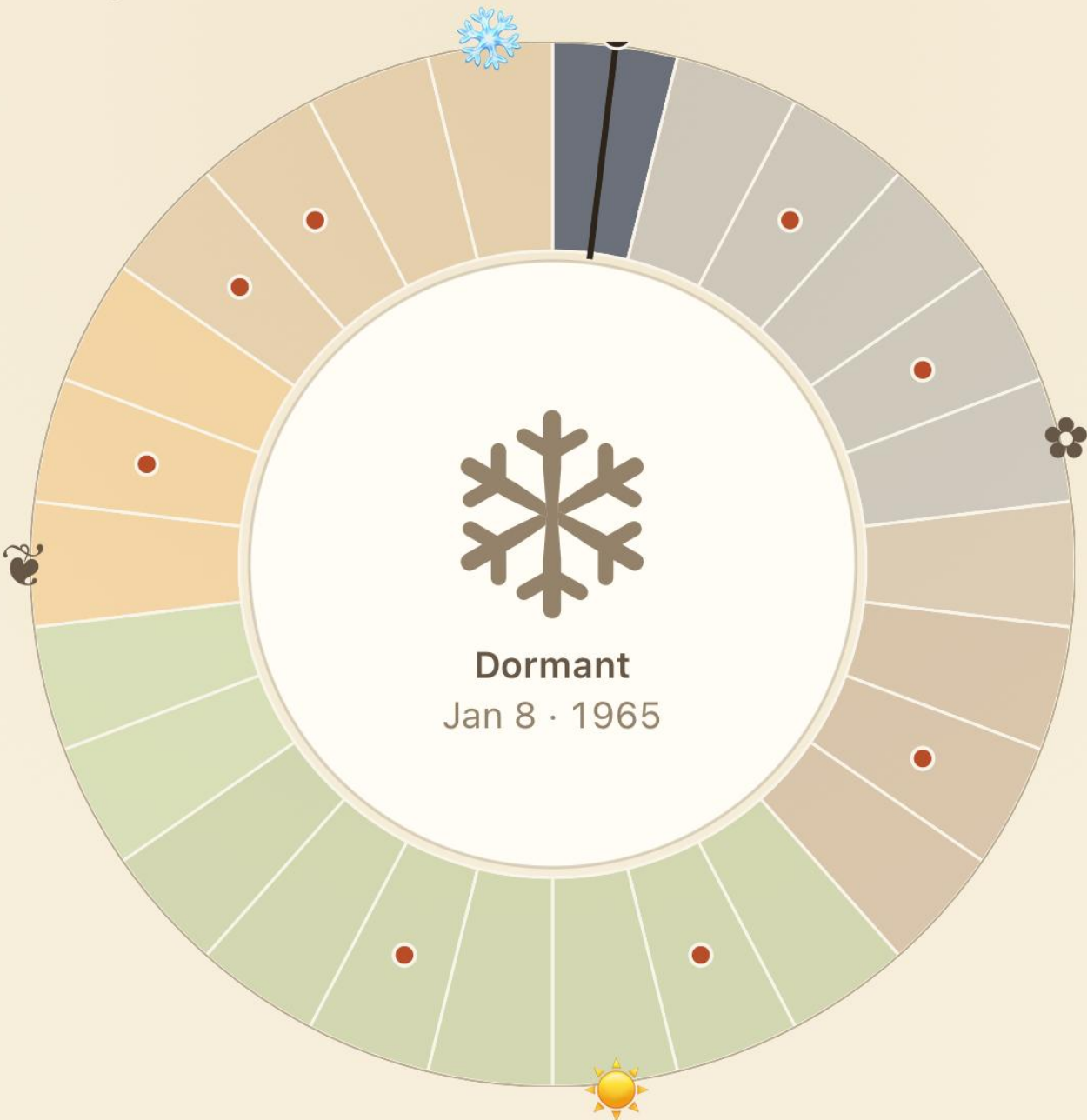
Fortnight 1/26

· What was written · settles into the soil ·

SEASON
XVI/XXX

EQUITY
\$46k

LAST YEAR
\$9k



THE NOTE ON THE FARM
\$12,800 still owed the bank

THE GROUND

HOLDING

ORGANIC MATTER
3.3% ↓

SOIL LIFE
Tired ↓

NITROGEN
0 lb ↓

Next: Plan next season · in 2 fortnights

Advance to next event

+ One fortnight

Fast-forward year



Field



Almanac



Settings

The Corn Belt Register

— NEW

AAA signed — the corn-hog program

Roosevelt signs the Agricultural Adjustment Act. Sign a contract, cut your corn acreage, and the government cuts you a check. The CCC will loan against your corn at 45¢.

 EFFECT ON YOUR OPERATION

The AAA corn-hog program is open — the CCC will floor your corn price this era.

· Filed at the county seat · Iowa · Anno 1933 ·



THE SEASON PLAN

Every field, one sitting

— FORTNIGHT 3 • OFF-SEASON

What goes where?



Set every field's crop and ration in one sitting. The ground supplies some nitrogen on its own — the bag only has to make up the difference.

— THE HOME EIGHTY

Loam

Corn

Soybean

Beans buy their own nitrogen and leave a little behind.

— THE BACK FORTY

Loam

Corn

Soybean

Beans buy their own nitrogen and leave a little behind.

— CREEK BOTTOM

Loam

Corn

Soybean

Beans buy their own nitrogen and leave a little behind.

• Feed the crop • not the creek •

of the field



Corn

 Set the plan



ANNO 1965

Year-end reckoning

Soybean · 160 acres · 28.6 bu/ac

— REVENUE

Gross revenue	\$10,425
Price-support payment	\$0
Total revenue	\$10,425

— COSTS

Seed	\$1,120
Nitrogen	\$0
Diesel	\$254
Pesticide	\$0
Land rent	\$0
Drying	\$0
Interest	\$41
Total costs	\$1,415

— NET INCOME

In the black.

Break-even \$0.28 · sold at \$2.28 · \$56/ac

\$9,010

(\$2,420)



Soil Record

Done



THE SOIL RECORD

Year by year, the ground measured

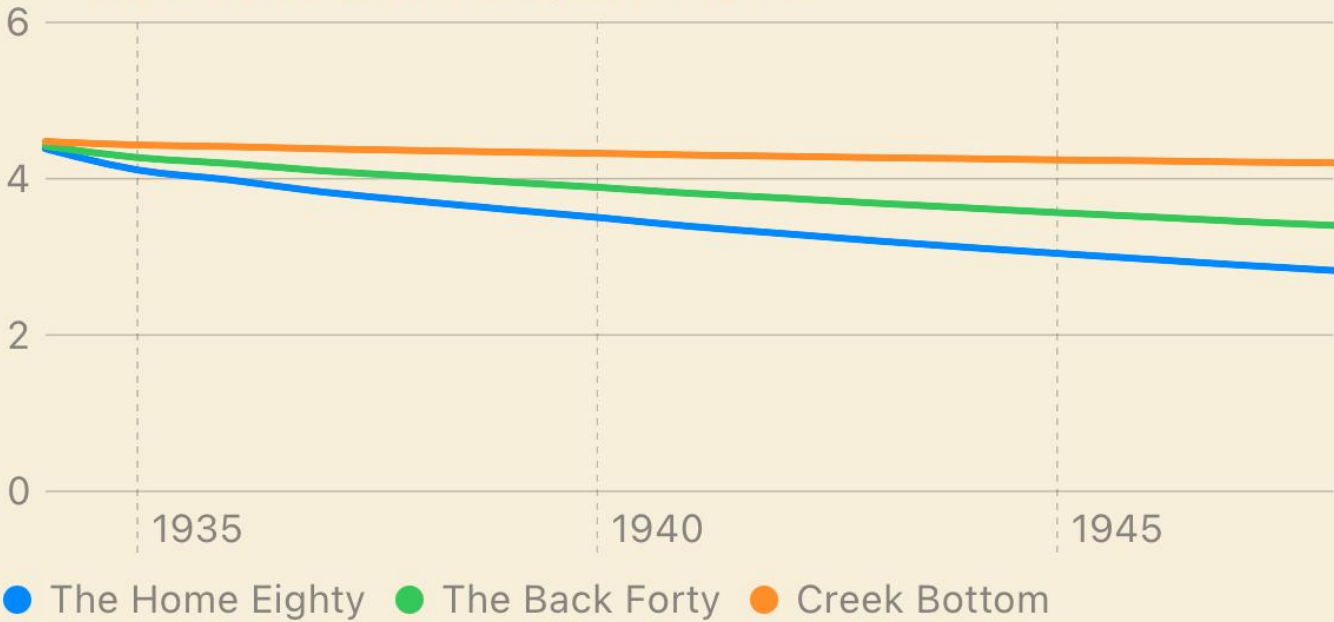
The county extension lab reads your samples now. What was once a matter of squeezing a handful and guessing is set down in numbers.



THE NITROGEN CYCLE, PLAINLY

Corn is a glutton for nitrogen, but nitrogen won't sit still. Legumes like beans, clover, and alfalfa, along with manure, put it into the ground. The living soil frees up more of it out of the air. Your corn crop takes it right back out. And a hard rain leaches off whatever's loose below the roots, and it's gone. Grow corn on corn with nothing feeding the bank and you'll mine it dry. That's why the rotation and the cover crop aren't chores. They're your deposit slips. Watch the nitrogen and the soil life together and you'll see the whole of it.

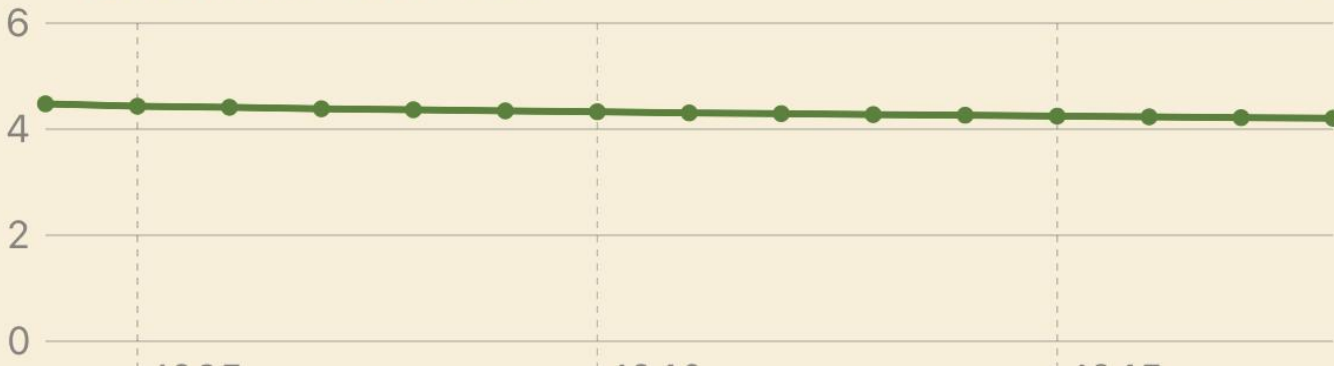
ORGANIC MATTER, BY FIELD

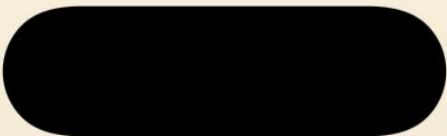


Same weather, same prices. Each field's ground follows what you grow on it. There's the whole notion, drawn plain.

ORGANIC MATTER

4.2 %





THE RECKONING

The Back Forty · 1933–1948

YOU HELD
THE GROUND

You kept what was handed you. No small thing, in these years.



Inherited	\$12,724
Left behind	\$12,724
The note	\$4,416 owed
Seasons worked	15
The ground you leave	4.5% → 3.3% OM
Best year	1947 · \$13,194
Hardest year	1937 · \$262